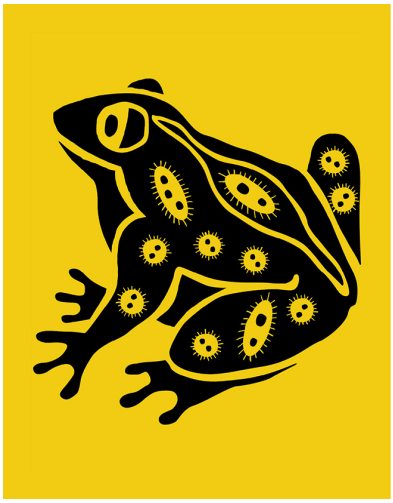


ONE OF THE MAIN THREATS TO BIODIVERSITY IS INFECTIOUS DISEASES

AMPHIBIAN VIRUSES

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Malcolm McCallum (1968–)

BEFORE

1989 The formerly common golden toad of Costa Rica is declared extinct. Various explanations are proposed.

1998 In the US, many poison-dart frogs die at the National Zoo in Washington D.C. The chytrid fungus is implicated as a cause.

AFTER

2009 The Kihansi spray toad of Tanzania is declared extinct in the wild as a result of chytrid infection.

2013 A second species of chytrid fungus causes the near-extinction of fire salamanders in the Netherlands.

2022 The chytrid fungus has been found in 1,375 amphibian species, and has led to the extinction of 90 species.

Since the 1980s, hundreds of species of amphibians have suffered population crashes and localized extinctions—at a rate thought to be more than 200 times the natural, “background” extinction rate unaffected by